Introduction:

This research report investigates the research of Dr. Lorna Warren, a member of staff at the University of Sheffield. We analysed her literature and conducted a semi-structured interview with her to achieve our overall research goal of determining whether ideas around age and ageing have become increasingly more positive or negative over time. This goal influenced our approach to analysing the literature and conducting the interview. We used qualitative methodology, including the interview and the analysis thereof, to answer our question.

Literature Review:

In order to undertake our goal, we first read three pieces of research from Lorna Warren. Firstly, Hopes, fears and expectations about the future (Clarke & Warren 2007): This paper looked at the older population and their feelings about the future. What stood out to me in this paper was the spectrum of perspectives that the interviewees approached the future with. The paper considers the possible flaws in the "active-ageing" paradigm and instead advocates for a "comfortable health ageing" paradigm, citing Reed et al (2003). To me this idea was best expressed by one of the interviewees, Gladys Peters, when she said "..you cannot stand still, you have to advance or deteriorate, and I like the advancement that comes with age".

The second paper, `the challenge of creating ‘alternative’ images of ageing` (Warren et al 2012), deals with the problem of representation of ageing in women. Through two participatory projects, one spearheaded by Laura Pannack and one by Monica Fernandez, the study attempts to break from the mold of Western "heroes of ageing/bodily decline" dualistic thought (Featherstone and Hepworth 1995 & Richards 2013) by offering an alternative depiction of older women. Laura Pannack creates a "nostalgic/melancholic" depiction of her sitters, yet this seems inconsistent with their lives. For example, Elaine felt like she happily lives in the present, meanwhile her portrait paints her as having a "preoccupation with the past" which is inconsistent with Elaine's self-assessment. Barbara also felt it more important to focus on the future and present rather than the past. In contrast, Moncia Fernandez shows the women having fun and dressing up, it feels like it places more emphasis on the present. I personally feel the goal of this project was closer to achieving the goal of creating alternative depictions of older women. Monica's goal is to

not to "present age denial" but to show how "ridiculous makeovers are as a way of concealing the ageing process".

In the third paper, ‘I’ve got lots of gaps, but I want to hang on to the ones that I have’ (Warren et al 2020), the researchers interviewed 43 older people living in the UK, aged 65-91. The intention of the study was to gain insight into the significance of the mouth over the live courses of the interviewees. The study found that through a process they called "mouth talk", the participants created narratives around "maintaining, losing, and replacing teeth to sustain their moral identity and sense of self in later life." I find most intriguing here how fitting the Goffmanian concept of frame analysis is in explaining what was observed in this study (Goffman 1974), participants "downplayed" the significance of their oral problems in a way that allows them to organise their experiences of ageing and make sense of it and the interactions in which it comes up in. In Goffmanian language, the primary frame is "ageing" and as a secondary frame of that process "mouth talk" manifests itself to organise the experience of the primary frame, ageing.

Methodology:

We used qualitative methodology for this study, because the semi-structured interview allowed us to build rapport with Warren to gain more in depth-data, and, in addition it allowed us to focus on her lived experiences as a researcher (Haney et al 2016, pp. 11). I and another researcher undertook the process of doing the semi-structured interview. Before the interview we took on crafting the script, one difficulty however was the unpredictable nature of the interview, as a result we found ourselves needing to prioritise certain questions over others and had to work these things out in the interview. Alongside the interview itself, it was also recorded using a phone and a transcript was produced thereafter. We all signed a consent form in order to make sure the process was done in line with ethical guidelines.

The initial literature review and the basic analysis of repetition allowed me to undertake hybrid coding (Swain 2018). I began with the a priori codes that presented themselves in the analysis seen in the table 1, and then undertook an inductive process of identifying codes within the interview, resulting in the emergent codes seen in table 2

Table 1:

A Priori Codes	Number of mentions
Older people	20
Life course	11
Teeth	13
Health	14

Table 2:

Emergent Codes
Social constructionism of age
Historical perception of ageing
Ageism and anti-ageing narrative
Positive aspects of older age
Tropes of ageing

The process of coding allowed me to gain a more thorough understanding of the ontological and epistemological frameworks Lorna is using alongside bringing me closer to a possible answer to our research question.

Results:

The life course was the only “constant” of the interview, with Lorna saying “people get to a certain age it's important to know their life course because it is essentially them”. This is consistent with the rest of the interview, in which the life course remained of significant importance. In addition, this focus on the life course is profoundly consistent with a constructivist social ontology, her qualitative focus in these studies and her remark in the interview that old people are the experts in their own ageing, they are the people we should ask about it. I sensed some very potent poststructuralist and postmodernist

influences with regards Lorna's approach to methods, epistemological interpretivism and her ontological constructivism (Orange 1998).

With regards to our initial question of whether perceptions of ageing have become increasingly more positive or negative over time, the answer seems to be ambiguous. In the code analysis, I found that there was more negative commentary on how society looks at ageing than there was positive. One very notable conclusion I made from this interview coding is that the negative stereotypes of ageing appear to be hegemonically ingrained into the concept of the life course, Lorna says there is this idea that retirement is a "withdrawing from doing things" and "that's how it is and the next generation moves in". These to me suggest that the problem of ageism stems in large part from the fact that it is the hegemonically dominant view of the life course that places later life in such passivity and dire straits, rather than some inherent quality of it. The interview further implies this is a problem that has gotten worse via the anti-ageing cosmetics industry and COVID. However, there is nuance here, Lorna mentions that although COVID tested how bad ageism truly is, a lot of people were angry about how old people were treated during the pandemic.

Historically Lorna mentions that starting with the homerics age there was this idea that wise older people were a significant part of society, "in Greek and Romans time, philosophers were people who have been around for quite some time", this concept is mentioned many times in the interview and always intersected between historical perception of ageing and the positive aspects. This perhaps implies there has historically been a great respect for the elder and less ageism, this is mentioned especially in the context of cross cultural social anthropology. At the same time, we need to be careful: ageism is not exclusively Western (Yaghoobzadeh et al 2020). On a final note, I observe that it is possible that the postmodernist rejection of meta-narratives has influenced Lorna's approach and this could explain the lack of a clear answer to our initial research question which seemingly requested some kind of meta-narrative - perhaps it was wrong to approach this with such a broad and seemingly macrosociological question.

Conclusion:

We started out with the intention of finding out if ageing and ideas around it have gotten worse or better over time via the lens of Lorna's work. In the analysis of the interview data, I found that this question has an ambiguous answer. The life course seems to be hegemonically supportive of ageist concepts and notions, and this is very hard to escape. In addition this problem is worsened by the anti-ageing cosmetics industry and modern beauty standards. However, the public outrage at the way older people were neglected during COVID suggests ableism is not as omnipresent as it can feel. It is important to consider the limitations of our research. Firstly, we approached a qualitative study with a very broad ranging research question, and secondly, in the interview itself, we struggled to know exactly which questions to prioritise and which not to. Finally, implicit in Warren's ontology and epistemology is the rejection of meta-narratives, possibly accounting for the lack of answer to our question from this research endeavor.

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